Group 3 — Not Worth the Ice: the threat is overblown

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Our position: Canada is about to spend more than $40 billion defending a frozen ocean that almost nobody sails, against an invasion that Canada's own government says is unlikely. Meanwhile, one in three Inuit homes in Nunavut is in poor repair and the public-housing wait-list is over 3,000 families long. Sovereignty panic is a politician's favourite way to look tough. We say: follow the evidence, and spend the money where Canadians actually live.

Briefing

Start with the threat. Prime Minister Mark Carney told the Davos forum in January 2026 that Russia is "without question" a threat in the Arctic, but added that it is "more prospective than actual" (Bloomberg, Jan. 20, 2026). Canada's own Arctic foreign policy says the immediate risk of a military attack in the North American Arctic remains low (Hashtag Investing, Sept. 2026). Alison LeClaire, Canada's former ambassador to Russia, said in April 2026 she does not believe Russia poses a physical threat to Canada in the Arctic, because Moscow needs stability there far too much to disrupt it (MBC Radio, Apr. 2026). A CBC analysis in September came to a similar "qualified no" (CBC North, Sept. 2026).

Now the prize. The Northwest Passage is often described as a future Suez Canal. In reality, 13 ships completed the full route in 2025, mostly cruise ships and a handful of Dutch cargo vessels, in a season that ran from August 6 to October 14 (Aker Arctic, Oct. 2025). The Panama Canal handles 36 to 38 ships per *day* (GeoGarage, Sept. 2026). Research led by Alison Cook and Jackie Dawson found that thick multi-year ice is actually pushing *down* into the Passage as the high Arctic melts, shortening the navigable season since 2007 (Economy.ac, Oct. 27, 2026). Only about 16 per cent of Canadian Arctic waters are surveyed to modern standards.

Now the cost. The March 2026 plan committed $32 billion to military bases alone, and the first new submarine will not arrive until 2034. When reporters asked, Carney acknowledged the plan contained no money for housing (CBC North, Mar. 2026). Yet more than 60 per cent of Nunavummiut rely on public housing, 45 per cent of it overcrowded,

and the median rent in Iqaluit hit $3,025 a month in 2025 (Nunatsiaq News, Feb. 2026; Nunatsiaq, Aug. 2026). In Nunavik, a house costs more than double what it does in Quebec City and the region is short 1,039 units (Soleica, Aug. 2026).

There is also the danger of the build-up itself. Russia's foreign minister Sergei Lavrov called NATO's Arctic militarization a direct threat to Russian security, and LeClaire warned that with Canada–Russia communication channels mostly closed, an accidental incident could escalate with no one to call (CBC North, Sept. 2026).

> "Every decade someone announces the Arctic is about to become a highway. The ice has heard this before. My patients have not heard that their clinic is getting a second nurse." — *Dr. Priya Raman, regional physician, Kivalliq* **[illustrative]**

Quotations marked [illustrative] are fictional composite voices written for readability. Real public figures are paraphrased from the linked reports.